

Sami Siddiqui

TECHNICAL DIRECTOR · HEAD OF ENGINEERING

I build game engineering teams, and the engines, tools and live ops behind free-to-play hits.

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US Pacific or EU hours · Available now

20+	14+	13	11M+
YEARS BUILDING GAMES	YEARS LEADING TEAMS	GAMES SHIPPED, 5 WITH LIVE OPS	DOWNLOADS

CAREER IMPACT

- **13 games shipped, 11M+ downloads** with publishers Tilting Point, Hazy Arts and Metamoki, including licensed games for *Narcos* and Wiz Khalifa (10M+ downloads, 4.8★ from 80K App Store ratings).
- **Built engineering twice:** grew Big Wolf from its only engineer to a team of 8–10, then built Tollan's in-house team; I now lead 16 contributors, including two outside studios.
- **One engine, three games, three publishers:** led the *Narcos* idle engine behind *El Patrón*, *Narcos: Idle Empire of Crime* and *High Tide*.
- **Live ops at scale:** 180 live events in one year on *El Patrón*; 50+ weekly live events and six seasons at Tollan.
- **Delivered under pressure:** when our blockchain partner announced its shutdown, players were on a new chain in 10 days and their items migrated in 22.

GAMES SHIPPED


Tollan Universe
2025



Spades (NDA)
2024


Narcos: Idle Empire
2023


High Tide
2022


El Patrón
2020


Idle Food Truck
2019


Wiz Khalifa's game
2017


Kush Krush
2016


Fruit Pop 2
2015


Sour Grapes
2014



Super Monkey Dive
2014



Dash Dot
2014


Karachi Racers
2005

EXPERIENCE

Chief Technology Officer, Tollan Universe

Dec 2024 – present · remote · HQ San Francisco

Browser action RPG with live ops. I own technical direction, architecture and delivery across the Unity client, web platform, backend and smart contracts.

- **Built and lead the engineering team:** started with three engineers I'd led at Big Wolf (the top four contributors in 2025); now 16 contributors, including two outside studios.
- **Set the technical direction:** 10 written architecture decision records; I own code review and releases.
- **Took the game from a GDC 2025 demo to launch** in May 2025, then through six seasons, Tollan 2.0 and 50+ weekly live events.
- **Shipped a platform migration under deadline:** moved the game to a new chain in 10 days and both NFT collections in 22, keeping every token ID.
- **Built the live-ops platform:** main engineer (79% of commits) on the Next.js platform behind the economy: currencies, store, missions, leaderboards, passes and admin tools.

- **Architected the game client:** gameplay systems behind 67 playable characters, 30 skills and 40+ enemy types, kept fast in the browser through the upgrade to Unity 6.
- **Changed how the team ships:** a spec-driven AI-agent workflow (specs to tickets, test-first, UI verified in Playwright).

Lead Engineer, Big Wolf Games — Dec 2013 – Dec 2024 · remote · HQ San Francisco

San Francisco free-to-play studio. I led engineering for 11 years and shipped 11 of my 13 games here, from prototype to live ops.

- **Built the engineering team from scratch:** the studio's only engineer from 2014 to 2016, then hired and led the team that grew to 8–10 engineers.
- **Led two idle-game engines:** the *Narcos* engine shipped three titles for three publishers (*El Patrón*: 1M+ Google Play downloads); I owned code review and releases (2,200+ pull requests).
- **Led the engine for Wiz Khalifa's official game:** 10M+ downloads, 4.8★ from 80K App Store ratings.
- **Ran live ops at scale:** built the live-events system behind 102 event themes across three games and 180 events in 2023 on *El Patrón* alone.
- **Let designers ship without app updates:** a spreadsheet-to-Unity config pipeline live through PlayFab and S3 (208,000+ values in 7 languages in one build), plus idle-economy and fight editors.
- **Took the studio into backend and multiplayer:** CombatKit, a deterministic Go battle engine compiled to WebAssembly that became a standalone product; a Go idle server on DynamoDB; Nakama modules; a real-time Spades server in Go on AWS Lambda.
- **Sped up builds:** a custom Unity Cloud Build pipeline with a Rust sprite optimizer.

Lead Developer, Sunbonnet Partners — Oct 2012 – Nov 2013 · Karachi

Led the team on Faculty Enlight for Barnes & Noble College, used across 714 college bookstores; Sunbonnet reports online adoption grew from under 5% to 40%, with 160,000+ users.

Sr. Software Engineer, Nybble Tech — Dec 2010 – Oct 2012 · Karachi

CRM, customer service and forex systems for clients worldwide.

Games, mods and freelance — 2005 – 2010

Flash games, GTA and Max Payne mods, and *Karachi Racers*, a full conversion of Midnight Outlaw I built solo in 2005.

Side projects: still building — 2012 – now · personal

Orcas, an open-source PHP framework that brought ASP.NET's WebForms model to PHP. I reverse-engineer games and engines and build my own: renderers, ECS and small engines in C++, Zig and Rust, on raylib, SDL3, OpenGL, Vulkan and WebGPU.

TECHNICAL DEPTH

Leadership: hiring and growing teams, technical direction, architecture decision records, code review, live ops, working with publishers and outside studios.

Game and engine: Unity and C#, Go, Rust, TypeScript, WebAssembly, deterministic and real-time multiplayer servers, live-config and build pipelines.

Platform and cloud: AWS (Lambda, DynamoDB, CDK, S3), Google Cloud, Cloudflare, PlayFab, Nakama, Next.js and React, PostgreSQL and Prisma, Redis, Docker, GitHub Actions, Solidity.